some precautions. This is because quantitative data cannot be understood as ends in themselves but rather as the base for firm explanations and interpretations of reality (Cardoso and Brignoli 2002). Also useful is Pierre Vilar's (1965) and Jean Bouvier's (1976) advice. As they remind us, taking into account its historicity and keeping a holistic perspective in view, the use of data should not exclude a qualitative interpretation of the process. Thus, in our analysis of the data, we will relate the internationalisation of Brazilian contractors to such issues as the international system, Brazilian foreign policy and the process of capital accumulation in Brazil and in the world. Regarding the documentation used, it is mainly composed of primary sources derived directly from the object of investigation. The principal body of documents consulted comes from the monthly journal *O Empreiteiro,* from its launch in February 1968 until the end of 2010, a total of 493 issues. In addition to the information culled from the journal, we gained access to other industry sources from company websites that give details about their overseas constructions.[3] Another type of primary source accessed was the memoirs of company heads and agents associated with the firm's internationalisation process containing some information on the subject under discussion. We completed these documents with such subsidiary sources as mass circulation periodicals,[4] news and materials related to the subject as well as secondary sources (mainly master's theses) where we extracted relevant facts on overseas civil construction contracts and contractors' experience with these projects.

The data was processed and certain questions were asked of the sources, which revealed such facts as the country where the contract was signed; the contractor responsible for the construction; other firms present or not in the consortium implementing the build; the name of works; the type of construction; the value of the works; date of the contract; period of execution; financers of the works; source of information. Even so, the data presented is preliminary and does not cover all the characteristics of the process.

With this method, we were able to register a total of 404 signed contracts since 1969 of which 368 were signed by 2010. With this, we had a few interesting results indicating certain tendencies in the movement of Brazilian firms towards internationalisation, such as their principal areas of activity, the degree of concentration of the works abroad in a few Brazilian firms, the dominance of certain types of works at the expense of others, the degree of state support through financing the contracts and the historical path of the transnationalisation process as well as its pace by identifying periods of intensification and periods of withdrawal.

From the quantitative treatment of the data, we verified regular tendencies